Facilitation Techniques

Twelve simple techniques for better group conversations, plus tips for remote and hybrid sessions.

Facilitate · Include Every Voice · Diverge, Then Converge · Remote & Hybrid

SESSION _____

FACILITATOR _____

1 Check-in

WHEN

Start: help everyone arrive and speak once early.

HOW

1. Ask one light question
2. Go round, a sentence each
3. No discussion yet

Voices heard early speak up later.

2 Silent Writing

WHEN

Before discussing, so ideas aren't shaped by the loudest.

HOW

1. Pose one clear question
2. Everyone writes alone, 3–5 min
3. One idea per sticky

Quiet people contribute as much as anyone.

3 Think · Pair · Share

WHEN

To deepen ideas before the whole group hears them.

HOW

1. Think alone for a minute
2. Discuss in pairs
3. Pairs share with the group

Pairs filter and strengthen ideas fast.

4 Round-Robin

WHEN

When a few voices dominate, or you need every view.

HOW

1. Go round in order
2. Each person speaks briefly
3. “Pass” is always allowed

Equal airtime, without putting people on the spot.

5 Affinity Clustering

WHEN

To make sense of many ideas quickly.

HOW

1. Put all stickies up
2. Move similar ones together, silently
3. Name each cluster

Silent moving avoids arguments about wording.

6 Dot Voting

WHEN

To prioritise a list in minutes.

HOW

1. Give each person 3 dots
2. Vote at the same time
3. Count, then discuss the top items

Vote together, so no one follows the leader.

7 Fist of Five

WHEN

To check support for a proposal or plan.

HOW

1. Everyone shows 0–5 fingers
2. Ask the lowest votes what's missing
3. Adjust and re-vote

Low votes are information, not obstruction.

8 Agreement Scale

WHEN

To show how far people really support a decision.

HOW

1. Offer a 1–5 or 1–8 scale
2. From “fully support” to “block”
3. Discuss the spread

Shows lukewarm support that a yes/no vote hides.

9 Timeboxing

WHEN

For any activity that could run on forever.

HOW

1. Agree the time up front
2. Show a visible timer
3. At zero, decide: stop or extend

Ending on time builds trust in the process.

10 Parking Lot

WHEN

When a useful topic is off the current agenda.

HOW

1. Write it on the parking lot
2. Move on
3. Review it before closing

Respects the idea without derailing the session.

11 Fishbowl

WHEN

For a big group to hear a small, focused conversation.

HOW

1. A few people talk in an inner circle
2. Others listen around them
3. Leave an empty chair to join

Lets a large group follow a real dialogue.

12 Check-out

WHEN

End: capture value and close the session well.

HOW

1. Each person says one takeaway
2. Optional: rate the session 1–5
3. Thank everyone

A score of 1–5 for time well spent tells you what to change.

REMOTE & HYBRID

One shared board Everyone works in it, not just the facilitator.

Everyone on their own device In hybrid sessions, room and remote are equal.

Use chat for silent writing Then paste ideas onto the board.

Name the roles Facilitator, timekeeper, scribe, tech help.

Break every 50 minutes Screens tire people faster than rooms.

Cameras optional Ask for voices and participation, not faces.

“Who hasn't spoken yet, and how could we make it easy for them?”

“Are we still exploring, or is it time to decide?”

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